

PARKS, PARKWAYS, AND PARK SYSTEMS

Your scheme should be comprehensively conceived.

— FREDERICK LAW OLNSTED and CALVERT VAUX

The naturalistic landscape presented relief from the rectangularity of the urban gridiron, but by itself the park could not redefine city form, and it had serious limitations as the instrument of social progress and civilization that Olmsted had hoped it would be. Central Park, for example, was so far from the populated areas of Manhattan that it was virtually inaccessible to those who lived in tenements miles to the south. Downing and other cultural leaders had advocated that New York's park provide recreational opportunities for people in the course of their daily lives, but the inadequacy—and to the poor, the cost—of transportation to the northern reaches of the city precluded Central Park's serving this function. Indeed, Olmsted conceded in 1870 that "for practical every-day purposes to the great mass of the people, the Park might as well be a hundred miles away." Only years after its construction would the park merit the epithet "central."¹

The differences between their preliminary (1866) and final (1868) reports on Prospect Park demonstrate how rapidly Olmsted and Vaux recognized the limitations of a single park, regardless of size and quality of design, and how radical were their prescriptions for a new urban form. In the preliminary report, which ended with a consideration of routes connecting the park to Brooklyn's suburbs, Olmsted and Vaux suggested the creation of a "shaded pleasure drive" extending west from the circular entrance at the park's southern end. This road would have a "picturesque character" and would wind over rolling countryside, between groups of trees and shrubs, and terminate at the ocean. The designers advised that this or another road sweep through the outskirts of the city and approach the East River. There a bridge or ferry might transport vehicles to Manhattan and, by another shaded drive, bring them to Central Park. "Such an arrangement," Olmsted and Vaux explained, "would enable a carriage to be driven on the half of a summer's day, through the most interesting parts both

of the cities of Brooklyn and New York, through their most attractive and characteristic suburbs, and through both their great parks." The drive would become a "grand municipal promenade," as fine a pleasure road as existed in any city in the world.²

In this preliminary report Olmsted and Vaux first articulated the need to extend the benefits of parks throughout the city, but their proposed treatment was still not a solution. A carriage drive, however noteworthy in design, could not possibly redress the high levels of congestion that already existed in large parts of many cities, nor would it significantly benefit those residents who most needed some temporary escape from the oppressiveness of the urban environment. In short, the proposed drive would have presented a series of handsome views, but only to those people who could afford to keep or hire a carriage—the wealthy.

Two years later, however, Olmsted and Vaux elaborated on this earlier suggestion and again attempted to look beyond the boundaries of the park and consider its place within the present and future metropolis. Their pretext was the Brooklyn Park Commission's recognition of the inadequacy of approaches to Prospect Park. But, whereas their 1866 report had only sketched the rudimentary outlines of a single "grand municipal promenade," in 1868 Olmsted and Vaux took a broader view. Studying the relationship of cities and parks in the historical context of urban growth, they realized that a street arrangement other than the gridiron could help promote a higher quality of urban life. Their analysis of the evolution of street plans, from huddled medieval cities to contemporary metropolises, marked a major turning point in the rural-urban dichotomy because the designers were able to welcome, instead of dread, the "accelerated enlargement of metropolitan towns." Such growth was no longer threatening, Olmsted and Vaux explained, because in terms of public health, social order, and educational and cultural institutions, "the larger each town has grown, the greater, on an average, has been the gain." During the nineteenth century, public health reforms and the delivery of urban services caused a decline in epidemic diseases and devastating fires. Two other developments that had improved city life, they explained, were the "abandonment of the old-fashioned compact way of building towns, and the gradual adoption of a custom of laying them out with much larger spaces open to the sun-light and fresh air." They illustrated this beneficial change by comparing the wretched conditions in Liverpool with those of the much larger metropolis of London, which, because of its great public parks, was a healthier place to live. London's parks served as the proverbial lungs of the city, purifying the air of deleterious gases and affording opportunities for healthful recreation.³

Olmsted and Vaux then explained that a large park should be

only one element of a comprehensive city plan. Improvements in public transportation systems promoted urban expansion, and made possible the separation of workplace and residence, but also increased the distance city dwellers had to travel to reach the country. The differentiation of business and domestic life stimulated additional demands for urban recreational facilities, as well as for new residential areas on the periphery of cities. Anticipating continued urban growth, Olmsted and Vaux proposed an alternative to the gridiron. They urged the creation of a "series of ways designed with express reference to the pleasure with which they may be used for walking, riding, and driving of carriages; for rest, recreation, refreshment, and social intercourse." This new stage in the history of street development, the parkway system, Olmsted and Vaux defined as "a general scheme of routes of approach to and extensions from the Park, through the suburbs, in which the sanitary[,] recreative[,] and domestic requirements of that portion of the people of the city living at the greatest distance from the Park should be especially provided for." If complemented by an extensive system of such drives the park would no longer be a welcome though distant retreat from the town but an integral component of the city.⁴

Olmsted and Vaux proposed that Brooklyn's parkways be 260 feet wide, with a central roadway, service roads, and pedestrian paths separated by plots of grass and six rows of trees (fig. 23). Such a street system would provide for the complete separation of commercial and recreational traffic, create shaded walks and tree-lined avenues, increase the desirability of neighboring lots as sites for middle-class houses, and act as a barrier to the spread of fire. Like the Parisian boulevards then being constructed by Baron Haussmann, Olmsted and Vaux's parkways were a conscious attempt to enhance the attractiveness of the city. Significantly, however, these parkways would be constructed on a residential rather than imperial scale.⁵

Olmsted and Vaux established the routes for two major parkways in Brooklyn—Ocean and Eastern—and soon after beginning work at Prospect Park they assumed control of all the squares and public spaces in the city. But they were unable to plan comprehensively for the metropolis of the future: a shortage of funds curtailed all park operations from November 1869 until July of the following year; then the economic panic of 1873 halted construction for the remainder of the decade. Because of these financial conditions Olmsted and Vaux terminated their relationship with the Brooklyn Park Commission in 1873. The park was then only partially complete and their comprehensive system of public spaces and parkways only a blueprint for a different urban form.⁶

During the summer of 1868 Olmsted and Vaux had an opportunity to implement precisely the kind of comprehensive system of parks and

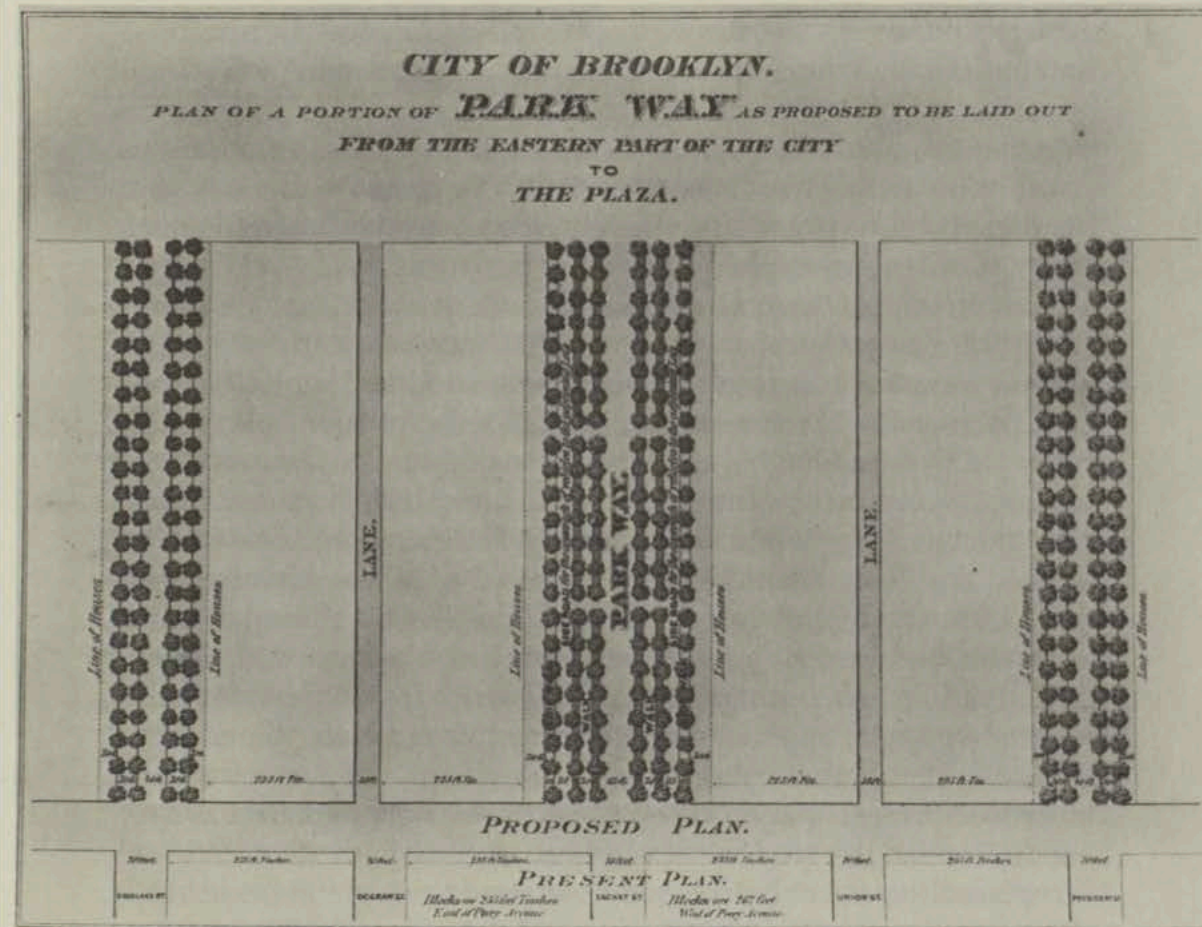


Figure 23. Plan of a parkway for Brooklyn, New York, by Olmsted, Vaux & Company, 1868. (Courtesy, The Brooklyn Historical Society, Brooklyn, New York.)

parkways they first sketched in Brooklyn. In August Olmsted addressed a public meeting in Buffalo, chaired by former president Millard Fillmore, and explained the necessity for and purposes of public recreational grounds. While in Buffalo he examined three potential park sites and was thus able, for the first time in his career, to determine what land would be chosen for park use. On October 1, after considerable study, the firm of Olmsted, Vaux & Company submitted their preliminary report—significantly, one that outlined the development not of a single park but of a comprehensive system of parks and parkways. As Charles Beveridge has pointed out, Olmsted's plan for Buffalo marked the "first demonstration of the form he hoped the expanding American city would take."⁷

In their report Olmsted and Vaux explained that the object of a park was to establish conditions that would "exert the most healthful recreative action upon the people who are expected to resort to it." An urban park, they explained should be "of a character diverse from the ordinary conditions" of life in the city. A park must be appropriately located, occupying a site "in which natural conditions, as opposed to

town conditions, shall have every possible advantage"; it must also contain desirable topographical features and space enough to permit the realization of large expanses of pastoral scenery. Almost by definition, the only undeveloped land conforming to these prerequisites would be located some distance from the built area of the city, and Olmsted and Vaux urged that parklike spaces be purchased in anticipation of urban growth.⁸

The principal feature of the Buffalo system was "The Park" (later renamed Delaware Park), a tract of some 350 acres located to the north of the city, near Forest Lawn Cemetery. Olmsted and Vaux described the large, meadowlike area of this site as "a series of open fields which are graced by a number of remarkably fine umbrageous trees, such as are never found except under unusually favorable conditions of soil and climate." Here was land that already resembled a park, and Olmsted and Vaux recommended that it be purchased immediately and transformed into the physical antithesis of traditional urban form. For the western part of the park they proposed damming Scajaquada Creek to form a 46-acre lake, which would provide for increasingly popular summer and winter sports and incorporate scenic effects different from those of the meadow and groves. Unfortunately, Delaware Avenue separated the two sections of the park; but as they had done with the transverse roads at Central Park, Olmsted and Vaux placed this street below grade and used thick plantings to block it from view, so that the sight and sound of traffic would interfere as little as possible with the sense of tranquility the visitor experienced while in the naturalistic landscape. They also made provision for the complete separation of vehicular and pedestrian ways inside the park.⁹

Based on their experiences in New York and Brooklyn, Olmsted and Vaux admitted that a large park should not be the only open public space within a city. The naturalistic landscape provided for "recreation of a decided character, involving an absence of some hours from ordinary pursuits," but as a result it could not meet the needs of most workers, except on Sundays or holidays, or of residents of distant neighborhoods. Thus, Olmsted and Vaux urged Buffalo's leaders to think of the park "simply as the more important member of a general, largely provident, forehanded, comprehensive arrangement for securing refreshment, recreation and health to the people." The city also needed smaller, more accessible parks "to which many can resort for a short stroll, airing and diversion, and where they can at once enjoy a decided change of scene from that which is associated with their regular occupation."¹⁰

To provide these other recreational opportunities Olmsted and Vaux recommended the acquisition of two additional sites for park use: the Front, a 32-acre tract adjacent to the Niagara River, and the

Parade, a 56-acre space near the eastern periphery of the city. The Front was a "comparatively elevated" ground, and Olmsted and Vaux predicted that, if developed as a park, it would provide spectacular scenic views of Lake Erie and the river and would possess a "character of magnificence admirably adapted to be associated with stately ceremonies, the entertainment of public guests and other occasions of civic display." They located at the Front a playground, a carriage concourse, an amphitheatre, and a large architectural terrace for musical events. The site of the proposed Parade was the highest ground in the city and had the additional asset of being "nearer to the more densely populated parts of the city than any other site having distinctive natural advantages." Olmsted and Vaux planned the Parade to include a level ground for military displays, a grove with the most modern play facilities for children, and Vaux's refectory, a large structure that would afford a place for "gregarious" recreation. Thus their plan for the three initial parks in the Buffalo system built upon the designs of Central and Prospect parks. Olmsted and Vaux provided for the differentiation of recreational spaces, using the Front and Parade as locations for functions that, while essential in a city, would be antithetical to the tranquility of a naturalistic landscape (fig. 24).¹¹

Olmsted and Vaux also prepared plans for a system of parkways. Designed to be the principal approaches to the park, these 200-foot-wide, tree-lined roads united the three parks and extended into the built area of the city. These boulevards would be "adapted exclusively for pleasure travel" and, as they contained "turf, trees, shrubs and flowers," would be "more park-like than town-like." Perhaps most importantly, these roads would extend to distant parts of the city the benefits of parks; they would be pleasure grounds "suitable for a short stroll, for a playground for children and an airing ground for invalids."¹²

Based on this preliminary report, Buffalo acquired the three sites for park development and, in May of 1869, entrusted their design to the firm of Olmsted, Vaux & Company. Construction began the following year and was superintended by civil engineer George K. Radford. As the parks and parkways took shape, owners of land on the northern and eastern borders of the principal park commissioned Olmsted and Radford to plan a residential subdivision. At least since his visit to Birkenhead, a suburb of Liverpool, during his walking tour of England in 1850, Olmsted had recognized the stimulus that a park could give to urban development; the rapid rise in property values and the accelerated construction of handsome houses in areas proximate to Central and Prospect parks had reinforced that belief. But the commission to lay out streets in "Parkside" was Olmsted's first opportunity to plan an urban residential neighborhood that would complement the naturalistic landscape of a park. With Radford he platted

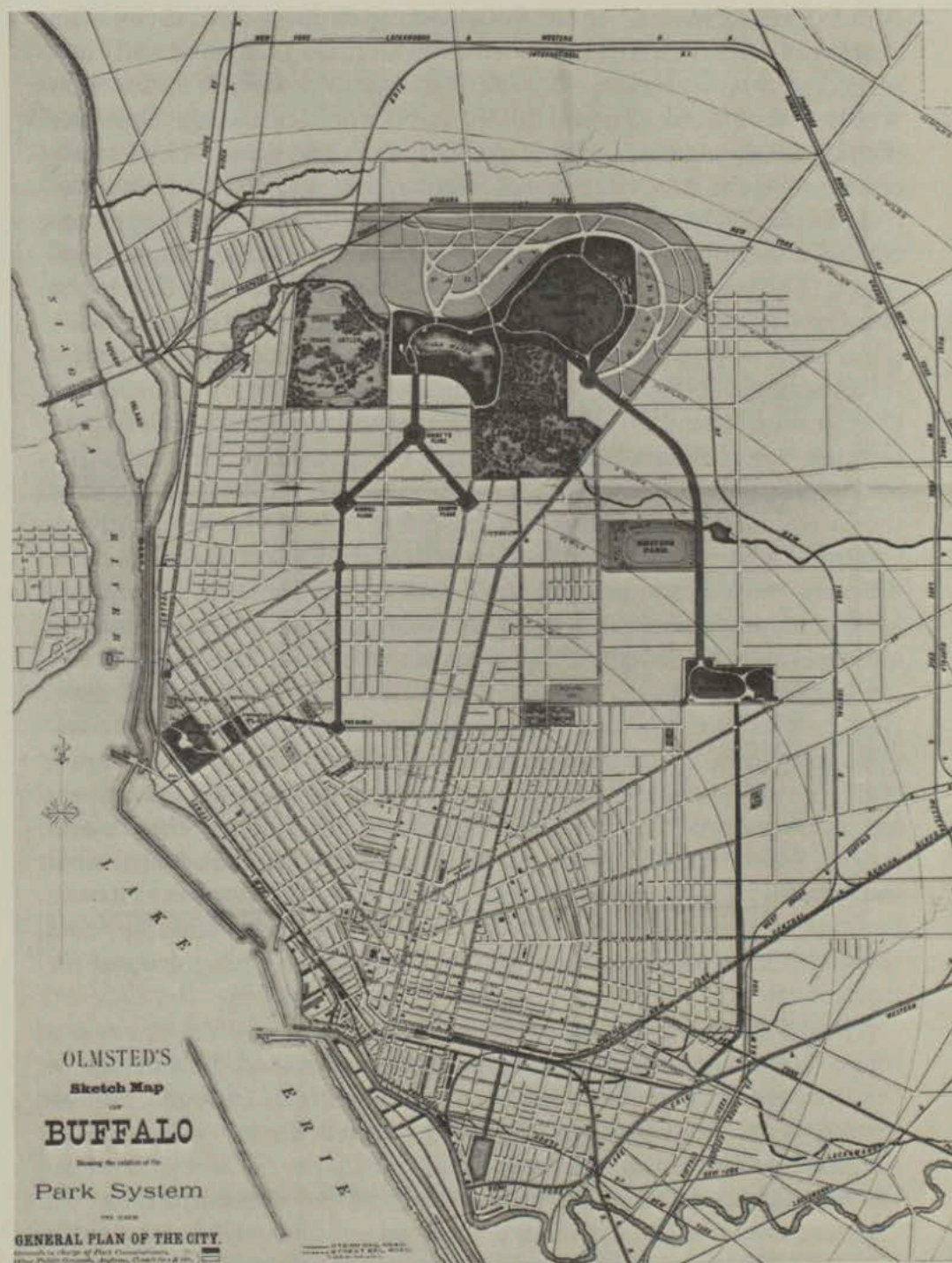


Figure 24. Plan of the park system for Buffalo, New York, by Olmsted, Vaux & Company, 1868. 1876 map showing parks and parkways in relationship to the city plan. (Courtesy, Center for Landscape Studies, Dumbarton Oaks, Trustees for Harvard University, Washington, D.C.)

curving, tree-lined streets, and divided the area into lots large enough for handsome homes and their grounds.¹³

Olmsted's association with the city of Buffalo continued intermittently for another thirty years. During most of that time his associate William McMillan superintended the parks, working assiduously to ensure the integrity of Olmsted's projects. Olmsted and his firm also designed other parks and squares in the city, including a system of parks and parkways in the southern end of town and the grounds of the New York State Asylum for the Insane, as well as a number of private residences. Thus, at Buffalo Olmsted had the opportunity to design a comprehensive park system and to watch it develop and evolve according to his principles of urban form. With the superimposition of his designs on Joseph Ellicott's original radial street plan, Olmsted believed, Buffalo was "the best planned city, as to its streets, public places and grounds, in the United States."¹⁴

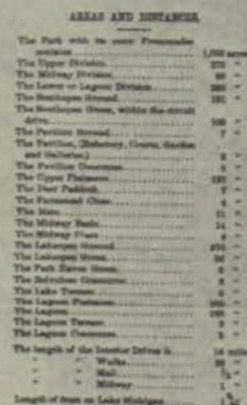
If Buffalo represents the first superb example of comprehensive park planning in the United States, Chicago exemplifies the persistence of political intervention and the continuing debate over whether the park should be a naturalistic or an educational and associational landscape. Chicago had set aside six small open spaces in the years between 1839 and 1864, but after the Civil War the city's leaders recognized that the existing recreational spaces were inadequate and moved energetically to provide their city with a comprehensive system of parks and parkways. In 1867, attorney E. B. McCagg sponsored a bill that sought to establish an extensive recreational area in the Hyde Park neighborhood; although the bill passed in the state legislature it failed to carry in popular referendum. Less than two years later the legislature approved the acquisition of three large parks, to the north, west, and south of the city, and Chicago's voters ratified creation of the western and southern parks in February of 1869.¹⁵

As the park question attracted increasing popular attention, landscape architect H.W.S. Cleveland attempted to focus the debate on issues of design. This transplanted New Englander warned Chicagoans not to copy existing park plans. Instead, he argued, "every city should adapt the style of arrangement of her public grounds to the peculiar characteristics of her condition and topographical features." Cleveland believed that Chicago would be foolish to follow the examples of eastern parks, because its flat topography was totally unsuited to that style of design: "nature has denied us many of the features which have been commonly considered indispensable to the full development of her charms," he noted, "and art can only supply their want to a limited extent." Despite its title, Cleveland devoted most of his pamphlet entitled *The Public Grounds of Chicago: How to Give Them Character and Expression* to a discussion of

Let the avenue form in its whole extent, an arboretum, comprising every variety of tree and shrub which will thrive in this climate, each family occupying a distinct section, of greater or less extent, according to its importance, in which all the skill of the gardener's art may be displayed, but in which all the artistic effect shall be produced by the use of varieties of the single family to which the portion is appropriated.

Cleveland undoubtedly hoped that the publication of his pamphlet would result in a commission to develop the Chicago parks, but none was forthcoming. The legislative acts establishing the park system appointed two separate commissions, neither of which selected Cleveland to plan these spaces. The commission charged with developing the south park solicited designs from the New York firm of Olmsted, Vaux & Company, while the men responsible for parks in the western part of the city selected local architect William LeBaron Jenney to lay out those grounds.¹⁷

In designing the south park Olmsted and Vaux determined to use to best advantage the landscape features of each division. For the tidal swamps adjacent to Lake Michigan in the lower park this required ingenuity not only in conception but also in engineering. They devised a scheme to drain the morass and, in its lowlying areas, exca-



Parks, Parkways, and Park Systems

vated earth to create a lagoon. Distributing the rich fill thus obtained they created the depth and quality of soil that would support stands of large trees. The designers also perceived that Lake Michigan provided an unusual means of access to the park: in the future, they predicted, "the toiling population of Chicago, relieved from work at an early hour on the last of the week, will be carried [in steamboats] to the South Park by many tens of thousands at the cost of a few cents." There they might walk, swim, play, or hire boats and follow an interior watercourse from the lagoon across the Midway to the smaller lake in the upper park.¹⁹

The land selected for the south park was flat and barren. As a result, Olmsted and Vaux could not create in Chicago the kind of naturalistic park they had in other cities. They did landscape the shores of the lagoon with lush tropical plants to convey to visitors a sense of the abundance of nature, and they shaped a sweeping expanse of lawn, the 100-acre "Southopen ground," in the upper division. But because they were planning only part of a much larger park system, Olmsted and Vaux could not make a series of parks differentiated by intended use. Thus, in addition to providing spaces for passive recreation, they also had to crowd a number of structures into the park, including a formal mall and an immense refectory in the upper division and a concourse, boathouse, terrace, Belvedere, aviary, and zoo in the lower. The political limitations of two park commissions and the topographical limitations of the south park site thus prevented Olmsted and Vaux from designing as comprehensive and imaginative a park system as they had in Buffalo.²⁰

Jenney's designs for the western parks (fig. 26), however, reasserted the function of the park as educational and associational. Douglas Park, for example, contained a refectory with a massive stone railing, a rotunda and cascade, a dairy and farmstead, a second refectory, and a formal concourse with bandstand. Instead of placing these structures in one part of the park, as Olmsted and Vaux had done at Central Park and as Olmsted later would do at Franklin Park, Jenney distributed them throughout the landscape. Moreover, he wanted each architectural element to be seen from the drive, thereby celebrating the structures that Olmsted and Vaux had conceded to be necessary in their first parks but had carefully hidden from view. In his design for Central (now Garfield) Park, Jenney confronted a problem Olmsted and Vaux had faced in their first collaborative effort: a site divided by roadways. Although he attempted to screen out of the park the traffic on these roads, Jenney was unable to maintain the aesthetic unity of the plan. The middle portion of the park was highly ornamental, with a large architectural terrace, a "byzantine" bandstand, a concourse, a refectory, and gardenesque beds of flowering plants. The southernmost part, intended to be educational, included

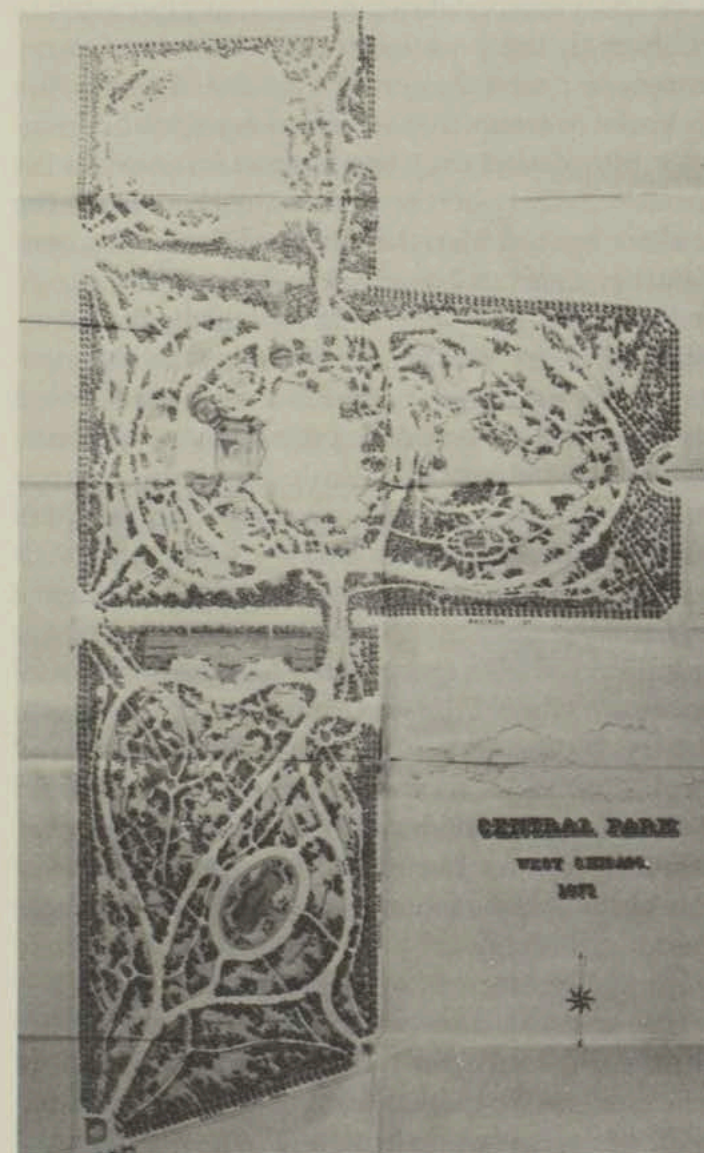


Figure 26. Plan of Central Park, Chicago, Illinois, by William LeBaron Jenney, 1871. (Courtesy, Library of Congress, Washington, D.C.)

a zoo, a botanical garden, and the site for a museum. Humboldt, the southernmost of the three parks, had a formal promenade and drive, a refectory, a carriage concourse, and an enormous bandstand adjacent to the lake. Most of these elements had appeared in Central Park or Prospect Park, but Olmsted and Vaux had abandoned them when designing the Buffalo system only the previous year.²¹

In his plans for Chicago's west parks Jenney revealed his French training in landscape engineering and architecture. His formal boulevards clearly owed more to Haussmann and Alphand than did Olmsted and Vaux's parkways, and his conception of the park was far closer to the ideas of another student of a French *école*, Richard Morris Hunt, than to those of the "dreamers" who in 1858 had designed New

York's Central Park. Indeed, whereas Olmsted and Vaux attempted to redefine city form by shaping the park as a naturalistic landscape, with sweeping expanses of pastoral scenery, Jenney devoted the largest expanses of his parks to water that served as foreground to architectural elements: he introduced only one important lawn in his three parks, a portion of the twenty-acre northernmost section of the Central Park—a space more limited than even the smallest of the constricted areas in the southern end of New York's Central Park.²²

The development of the Chicago parks thus represents the recurrence of the debate over park form that began with the 1858 competition for designs of New York's Central Park and that reached a critical point in the battle over Richard Morris Hunt's proposed monumental gateways. The differences separating the Olmsted-Vaux and Jenney plans might have invited comparison, perhaps even clarified park purposes and design, but neither the south nor the west parks took the shape their designers intended. The great fire of 1871 halted most park construction by diverting resources into the rebuilding of the city; then the economic panic of 1873 exacerbated Chicago's financial distress. Twenty years later, when Olmsted returned to the city to help plan the site of the World's Columbian Exposition, he found Jackson Park still, for the most part, a swampy morass. Olmsted modified his earlier design to create an appropriate setting for the exhibition, and under the direction of Daniel H. Burnham a group of talented architects created the monumental white city that rose there in 1892 and 1893.²³

Like other major eastern cities, Boston began applying the lessons demonstrated in Central Park soon after public acknowledgment of the Olmsted and Vaux design. Upon acquiring the Public Garden from private investors in 1859, and designating that land for park purposes, the City Council advertised a competition for designs. They awarded the prize to George F. Meacham, but his plan, complete with buildings, fountain, and formal axis, was closer in intent to Fort Greene Park and to Downing's Washington Mall than it was to a naturalistic landscape. It was really more an extension of the city than an escape from it. Nevertheless, the Public Garden, together with the Boston Common, was important in any program of park development in Boston. H. W. S. Cleveland pointed out that because of the proximity of these spaces to the center of population, Boston was better provided with parks than any city in the country. But because the city was already so intensively developed, the creation of a single park as large as New York's within the corporate limits would be impossible.²⁴

Boston began developing the Public Garden according to Meacham's plan in 1859. After the Civil War, however, civic leaders

recognized the need for a much larger park. In 1869 the City Council appointed a special committee to study the park issue, newspapers were inundated with letters outlining design proposals, citizens expressed their desires in public hearings, and H. W. S. Cleveland and others offered suggestions for park development. Cleveland rightly recognized that, because of the limited amount of available space, any large park for Boston would have to be located outside the city. Boston had "neither the necessity or the power to create a park such as New York's," he wrote, "without going so far beyond her limits as to render it comparatively of little value." Instead of a large, centrally located park, he advocated the improvement of roads and avenues outside the city with parklike scenery that might provide residents some of the sights and sounds of the country.²⁵

Cleveland's proposal anticipated Boston's metropolitan park system, but he presented it at a time when the city was still largely confined to the peninsula. Its major shortcoming was the city's inability to acquire the necessary land beyond its boundaries. Cleveland dealt with this by proposing that the suburban properties remain in private hands, though he did not explain how, without being under the city's control, this area would remain parklike as the process of urban decentralization accelerated. Robert Morris Copeland appreciated the impact of urban and suburban development on these areas, citing Roxbury, a once-charming rural neighborhood that had been transformed into "rows and blocks of very inferior houses, too many of them tenantless." Copeland also outlined a plan for a ring of suburban parks in 1869, as did attorney Uriel H. Crocker, but again Boston lacked the authority to develop an ambitious series of parks beyond the city line.²⁶

As debate over the location of parks continued, supporters invited Olmsted to Boston, and on February 25, 1870, he delivered an address at the Lowell Institute entitled "Public Parks and the Enlargement of Towns." Olmsted pointed out the necessity of a metropolitan solution to the city's recreational needs: "The Boston of today is the mere nucleus of the Boston that is to be. It is practically certain that it is to extend over many miles of country now thoroughly rural in character." Thus it would be foolhardy to limit consideration of park sites to the town, because continued urban and suburban growth would surely increase the distance separating country and city.²⁷

Three months after Olmsted's lecture, the state legislature approved an act enabling Boston to establish a metropolitan park system, including a ring of suburban parks. But the law required that two-thirds of the city's voters support the measure in referendum, which failed because too many residents of working-class areas feared that they would be taxed to pay for recreational spaces that would be inaccessible to them. It was only after Boston began annex-

ing surrounding territories in 1870 and 1873 that a comprehensive metropolitan park system became a political possibility.²⁸

Despite this initial setback the park issue retained considerable support in Boston. Copeland followed up his initial suggestions with a book, *The Most Beautiful City in America: Essay and Plan for the Improvement of Boston*, which he published in 1872. In it he modified his earlier proposal and recommended that a series of parks be developed within the newly annexed areas of the city—undoubtedly a concession to the sentiment voters had expressed in the park referendum. Unlike his earlier essays, this advocated specific sites for park development, including an area near the “new lands” of Back Bay at Parker Hill and additional locations in Dorchester and in the recently annexed parts of West Roxbury. Numerous other individuals stepped forward to offer suggestions. These various proposals and activities were the beginnings of what became Boston’s Emerald Necklace, the nation’s first comprehensive metropolitan park system.²⁹

The process of translating these proposals into landscape began in 1874, when Mayor Samuel Cobb appointed a special commission to study the park issue. The commission held public hearings and, in its report, recommended the creation of a park along the Charles River. The commission also expressed the hope that “a series of parks of moderate size, connected by proper roads, be laid out between the third and fourth mile circles; and that the land for a second series of larger size, beyond the first, be secured at once” for future development. This 1874 report thus sketched the outline of a series of peripheral parks united by parkways. It also testified to the effects of urban decentralization: land for park development between the three- and four-mile circles was limited because suburbanization was proceeding so rapidly. Thus, the only available land for large naturalistic parks was located on the advancing urban frontier.³⁰

Following the publication of this report the City Council passed a second Park Act. This law stipulated acquisition of land only within the limits of Boston. Upon approval of the measure by citizens, Cobb appointed a municipal park commission, chaired by Charles H. Dalton, to oversee development. The new commission studied suggestions for park locations and examined numerous plans but found none that measured up to its expectations of what a park should be. The commissioners then invited Olmsted to offer advice on the land being considered for park use, and on two occasions he visited the sites and proposed modifications in their boundaries. After Olmsted’s second visit the park commission published its initial report, a comprehensive scheme that advocated the establishment of a number of smaller parks in the populated areas of the city and larger recreational spaces in the newly annexed wards, all joined by a system of parkways. The land included in this scheme eventually became the

three principal elements of the Boston park system—the Fens, Jamaica Pond, and Franklin Park.³¹

Although financial difficulties delayed implementation of this plan, the Boston park commission acquired the land for the Back Bay park (the Fens) in 1878. This first park was necessary as a sanitary measure to provide adequate drainage of Muddy River and Stony Brook, tidal estuaries that flowed into the Charles River. To obtain the best plan for the Fens, the commissioners held a competition, but, finding all the entries unsatisfactory, rejected them and instead invited Olmsted to undertake the improvements. At the same time, Olmsted was collaborating with Charles Sprague Sargent on a plan for the Arnold Arboretum, which was being developed by Harvard on land leased by the city to the university on condition that the facility be open to the public. These projects launched Olmsted’s public design career in Boston and made him the logical choice to develop the five-hundred-acre West Roxbury park later named in honor of Benjamin Franklin.³²

Olmsted described the most important element of the West Roxbury park site as “a gentle valley nearly a mile in length, and of an average breadth between the steeper slopes of the bordering hills of less than a quarter of a mile.” He informed Dalton that, when improved, the site would incorporate “a type of scenery which is perhaps the most soothing in its influence on mankind of any presented by nature”—the sweeping lawns and gently rolling hills, visually endless in extent, that he characterized as pastoral scenery.³³

Olmsted began devising his plan for Franklin Park (fig. 27) in 1884 and submitted it to the park commission near the end of the following year. As he and Vaux had done in the lower half of Central Park, Olmsted divided the Franklin Park site into two unequal areas according to their topography, scenery, and intended use. The larger part, the Country Park, consisted of heavily wooded areas ranging across the surrounding hills (named the Wilderness) and a sweeping greensward in the valleys below (named the Nazingdale). The Country Park incorporated the breadth of naturalistic scenery Olmsted considered essential in an urban park and provided space for group activities as well as individual contemplation of nature. Unlike the plans he and Vaux had devised for the Buffalo park system, this design did not limit the use of Franklin Park to these purposes only. He devoted a third of the space within the park’s boundaries to an antepark and there located playgrounds, a formal pedestrian mall called the Greeting, a music concourse, and a deer paddock. But, as he and Vaux had done at Central and Prospect parks, Olmsted carefully shaped the elements of the design so that these provisions for more active or “gregarious” recreation would not be visible from the naturalistic landscape.³⁴



Figure 27. Plan of Franklin Park, Boston, Massachusetts, by Frederick Law Olmsted, 1885. From *Notes on Franklin Park and Related Matters* (Boston, 1886). (Courtesy, National Park Service, Frederick Law Olmsted National Historic Site, Brookline, Massachusetts.)

As the development of Franklin Park continued, Olmsted devoted his attention to completing the Emerald Necklace. During the last eight years of his professional career Olmsted and his growing firm prepared designs for Jamaica Pond, for the Muddy River Parkway, which connected Jamaica Pond with the Fens, for Marine Park and Charlesbank, and for numerous smaller parks in the city. He also undertook a number of designs for suburban areas, including the Brookline Hill subdivision and Planter's Hill and World's End in Hingham. These plans were visionary, but Olmsted continued to be hindered in developing the comprehensive metropolitan park system he had advocated in "Public Parks and the Enlargement of Towns." Despite annexation, Boston's legal limits still incorporated only a fraction of the greater city; and, as Charles Eliot observed near the end of 1890, "the other municipalities within the metropolitan district are allowing their few remaining open estates to be divided and built upon one by one and year by year." Suburban growth was threatening to destroy the natural features that surrounded Boston.³⁵

The metropolitan park system envisioned by Cleveland, Cope-land, Crocker, and Olmsted was a logical way of providing recreational space for Boston and its neighboring municipalities. But because Olmsted's parks were located within city limits, the more comprehensive program of park development became a reality only in the 1890s. The major promoters of the metropolitan concept were Charles Eliot, son of Harvard president Charles W. Eliot, who had studied landscape architecture with Olmsted, and Sylvester Baxter, a journalist who a year later published *Greater Boston*, a pamphlet that pointed to the necessity of comprehensive solutions to problems long unsolved because of political boundaries that had created artificial divisions and had impeded common action. On March 5, 1890, Eliot published in *Garden and Forest* a letter entitled "The Waverly Oaks: A Plan for their Preservation for the People." This letter advocated the establishment of an organization that would preserve "surviving fragments of the primitive wilderness of New England... as the Public Library holds books and the Art Museum pictures—for the use and enjoyment of the public." The same year, Eliot solicited the support of members of the Appalachian Mountain Club. He called public meetings, publicized the need for open spaces, and orchestrated the campaign to introduce a bill in the General Court creating the Trustees of Public Reservations. That bill became law on May 21, 1891, and Eliot was appointed secretary to the trustees.³⁶

Following Eliot's recommendations the trustees surveyed the existing open spaces in Massachusetts, paying particular attention to long-neglected coastal areas, and attempted to promote a more comprehensive treatment of parks in the Boston metropolitan area. The trustees called a meeting of all park authorities from the Boston area

in December of 1891, and on that occasion Eliot spoke bluntly about political interference. He described the "ridiculous town boundary difficulty" that "prevents concerted action" in framing metropolitan solutions to metropolitan problems. Numerous speakers echoed Eliot's remarks, and after the meeting the trustees petitioned the General Court to establish a park system that transcended local boundaries. The legislature approved a bill to form a temporary metropolitan park commission, which the governor signed in June of 1892. Then Eliot's work really began, because the temporary commission had to submit a comprehensive report at the next session of the General Court. As secretary to that commission, Eliot suggested that a metropolitan park system embrace five types of areas—oceanfront beaches, the shores and islands of the bay, tidal rivers and estuaries, large expanses of native forest, and smaller parks in the built areas of the city. The commission adopted Eliot's recommendations and forwarded them to the General Court, which enacted a bill that, when approved by the governor, established the Metropolitan Park Commission. Between his appointment as landscape architect to the commission and his untimely death in 1897, Eliot directed the creation of America's first metropolitan park system (fig. 28). In some ways he built upon earlier proposals—especially those that foresaw the need for parks located on the periphery in anticipation of urban growth—and in other ways he grafted on to the evolving ideology of the public park the conservationist principles of the Progressive Era.³⁷

During the years in which Olmsted and Eliot labored in Boston, other cities developed park systems of commendable extent and design—H. W. S. Cleveland's proposal for Minneapolis is an example, as is the Olmsted firm's plan for open spaces and residential neighborhoods in Atlanta—but Boston's metropolitan park system marked the culmination of the evolution of the naturalistic urban landscape in nineteenth-century America. Charles Sprague Sargent gave classic expression of this park ideal in an 1888 essay published in *Garden and Forest*.

An urban park is useful in proportion as it is rural. The real, the only reason why a great park should be made, is to bring the country into the town, and make it possible for the inhabitants of crowded cities to enjoy the calm and restfulness which only a rural landscape and rural surroundings can give. . . all other objects must, in a great park, be subordinated to the one central, controlling idea of rural repose, which space alone can give.³⁸

As Sargent's remarks demonstrate, what began as a somewhat vague and generalized belief that parks were necessary measures for protecting public health and providing recreational opportunities gradu-

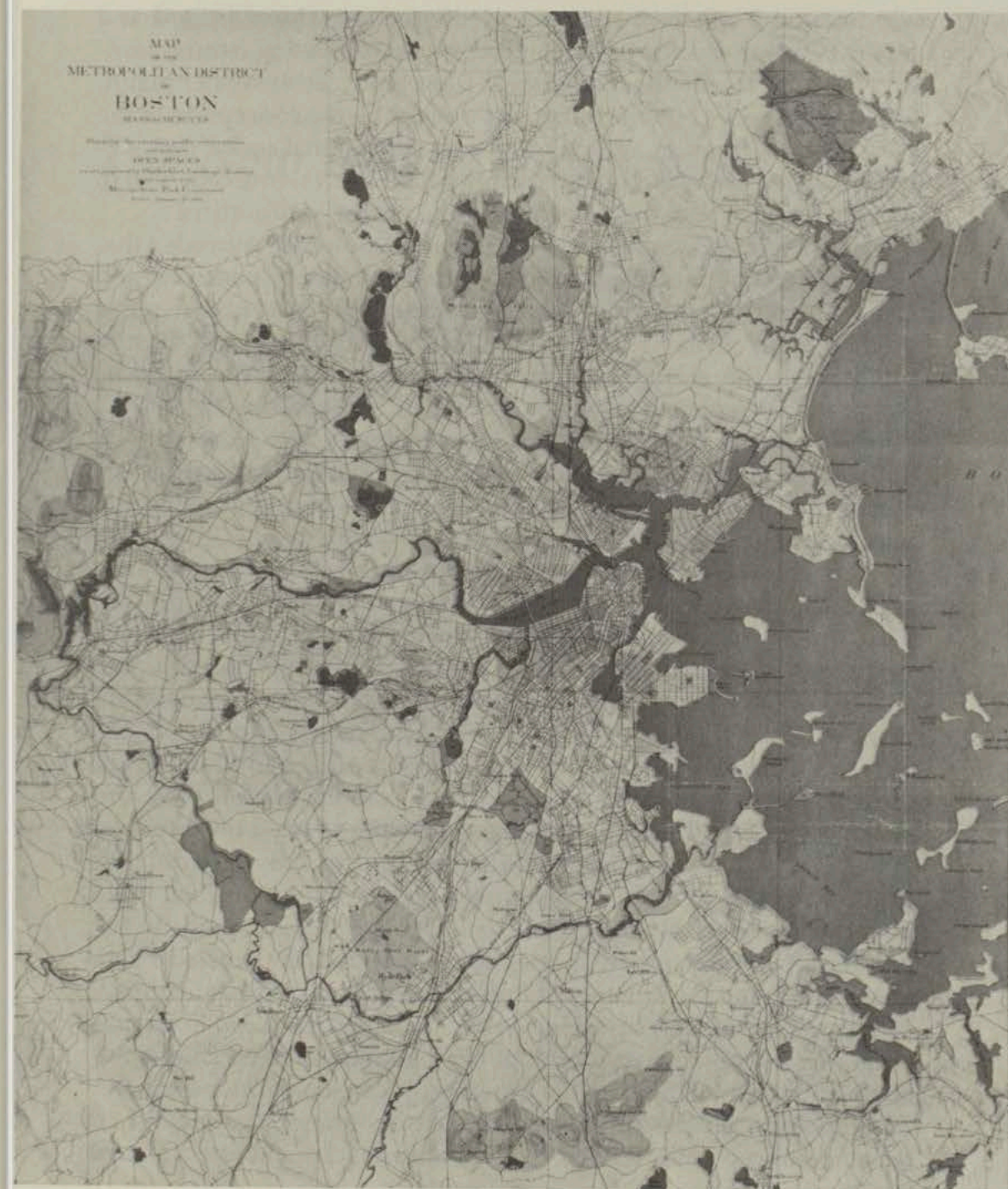


Figure 28. Metropolitan Boston in 1893. Prepared by Charles Eliot for the Metropolitan Park Commission, showing existing and proposed open spaces. (Courtesy, National Park Service, Frederick Law Olmsted National Historic Site, Brookline, Massachusetts.)

ally became a coherent program predicated on what Olmsted and others believed was the psychological impact of viewing natural scenery. Thus, in the hands of Olmsted, Cleveland, Jacob Weidenmann, Eliot, and others—but, of course, not everyone—the conception of the park evolved from an associational and educational space that was essentially an extension of the city into a naturalistic landscape that in its very rusticity was the antithesis of the urban environment.

Promoters and landscape architects alike, however, conceded that large naturalistic parks needed to be complemented by parkways and smaller recreational areas to which people could resort in the course of their daily lives. The plans for Buffalo, Chicago, and Boston represented the effort—with varying degrees of success—to create comprehensive park systems and provided, in Buffalo's case, for the differentiation of recreational spaces according to use. Moreover, the parkways and boulevards were consciously conceived not only as linear extensions of the parks but also as a means of providing openly built neighborhoods for residential development.

Because most urban areas in nineteenth-century America retained the traditional boundaries of the walking city—three to four square miles—not even the most imaginative municipal park systems could provide adequate recreational spaces in anticipation of urban expansion. As early as 1869 the spokesmen advocating park development in Boston had recognized the need for such planning, but the vision of a metropolitan park system was not realized until the 1890s, by which time the effects of unplanned decentralization were unmistakable. Only then did politicians and citizens heed the advice of Olmsted and Eliot and forsake community control, only then did they invest authority for park development in a commission that could plan comprehensively for the needs of a modern metropolis. In the last decade of the century Charles Eliot expanded on Olmsted's park ideal by forming the Trustees of Public Reservations, a private organization dedicated to preserving what remained of New England's wilderness. The ideology of the public park had evolved from tenuous beginnings to embrace the Progressive conservation movement: though physically distant from them, metropolitan park systems had become conceptually related to the Adirondacks and the national parks.

PART THREE

The New Urban Landscape